substantially dilute the Farmers' Produce Trade and Commerce (Promotion and Facilitation) Act, 2020.

Most state governments chose the first option. Surprisingly, no state, including the BJP governments, went for the second option although that would have been the most constructive. While there was no overt use of the third option by any particular state, the farmers' agitation launched in November 2020 was in that direction.

A key objective of establishing the APMC system was to provide a fair and level playing field to farmers in trading practices, charges and payments. The Farmers Produce Act 2020 literally created anarchy. No regulated marketing regime was made applicable to trade transactions undertaken under the 2020 Act. There was no regulator either. Electronic trading platforms were supposed to, on their own, 'prepare and implement guidelines for fair trade practices such as mode of trading, fees, technical parameters, including interoperability with other platforms, logistics arrangements, quality assessment, timely payment, dissemination of guidelines in the local language of the place of operation of the platform and such other matters'. The Central government had indicated that it might frame some of these regulations if it wished to.

For physical trades, there was no requirement of such self-regulation at all. With respect to agricultural produce, there is an uneven relationship between farmers and traders, which this Act did not recognize or safeguard.

Implementation of the Act was expected to have been chaotic and bumpy, but the reform was likely to do a lot of good in the long run. The final outcome, however, was a big let-down. Farmers' Produce Trade and Commerce (Promotion and Facilitation) Act, 2020 was simply repealed, undoing its reform elements as well. It would have to resurface at some stage again with the core reforms remaining intact—maybe on the lines of how FDI in multi-brand retail was handled—the Parliament passes an